(2005) and the Asian Defence Ministers Meeting-Plus (2010). The engagement with ASEAN-centred organizations has been complemented by renewed investments in BIMSTEC, which is meant to bridge South and Southeast Asia. The new level of diplomatic priority accorded the region has resulted in the creation of a separate Indian Ambassador to ASEAN, a dedicated division in India's Ministry of External Affairs and India-ASEAN Summits such as that held in 2018, in New Delhi, during which all ten Southeast Asian leaders appeared as chief guests for India's Republic Day celebrations.

A second element of India's relations with Southeast Asia—security—remains modest but has made some important strides in recent years. In relatively short order, India has strengthened its security relations with Singapore, Vietnam, Myanmar, Thailand, the Philippines, Indonesia, and Malaysia. With several of these countries, joint exercises and port visits have become routine. India conducts coordinated naval patrols and has provided technical assistance to several militaries, including Myanmar, with which counterterrorism cooperation remains important. Meanwhile, Singapore uses Indian territory to train its mechanized forces and artillery and Indian air space for air force drills. In 2017, India and Singapore also concluded a significant maritime agreement. With Vietnam, India is involved in training its air force combat pilots and submarine sailors. Since their origins in 1995, the MILAN maritime exercises represent an Indian effort at building naval cooperation and confidence with regional partners, including—but not limited to—the maritime forces of Southeast Asia. More recently, India has started to provide military equipment, including offshore patrol vessels to Vietnam, BrahMos cruise missiles to the Philippines, and a second-hand submarine to Myanmar. [33] India can still build upon these efforts to increase joint naval repair and maintenance facilities, and improve cooperative maritime surveillance and intelligence.

Perhaps the most challenging element of India's Southeast Asian engagement—rather ironically—was the original driver of relations: economic and commercial cooperation. In terms of trade, India is the seventh largest trade partner of ASEAN (if the EU is considered a single